The Family Meeting About Mom's Future Care

Who should be there, what to ask her and what to leave open.

Mom told your sister she'd never leave the house. She told you she wouldn't mind somewhere with people around. Each of you has heard a different piece, and nobody has heard all of it in one sitting.

This guide is for one unhurried conversation with one job: hear what Mom would want if she ever needed more help, and write it down. It isn't for deciding anything.

Who should be there

Mom, first. It's her future, and the meeting is for hearing her. Then the family members who would take part in planning: the one who lives closest, the one who helps with her bills, the one who lives far away and phones every Sunday. Someone who can't come can join by phone or send notes ahead.

The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests including everyone who is or will be part of the caregiving team, which may include a family friend or a neighbor. [1]

Pick one person to take notes. It shouldn't be the person leading the conversation.

How to open

Choose an ordinary day, at her table, with no paperwork out. Start with a question, not a plan.

The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests preparing an agenda before a family meeting. The questions below can be yours. Send them to everyone beforehand, Mom included. [1]

- “Mom, nothing needs to change. We'd like to hear what you'd want if you ever needed more help, so we'd be going by your wishes and not our guesses.”
- “Each of us has heard a different piece of what you'd want. We'd like to hear all of it, from you, together.”
- Say what the conversation is for: hearing her, and writing it down. Say what it isn't for: deciding where she lives, or anything about her money or her legal papers.

Questions to ask

Ask Mom

1. If you needed more help one day, where would you want to be?

2. If that couldn't work out, what would be your second choice?

3. Who would you want helping you, and is there anything you'd rather family didn't do?

4. If you couldn't manage your money or make healthcare decisions for a while, who would you want handling each?

Ask each other

1. What could each of us realistically do if Mom needed more help, and what couldn't we?

2. What has each of us noticed lately, and when?

3. What kind of change would make us sit down together again?

4. What don't any of us know yet, such as what care costs near Mom or which places she'd consider, and who could we ask?

How to write down what was said

Write Mom's own words first, and keep them separate from what the family thinks. Where two people see something differently, write both and don't settle it. Put a name in the last column only when someone has offered to take a question somewhere.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT	SEEN DIFFERENTLY BY	WHO WILL ASK, AND WHOM
“I want to stay in this house as long as I can. If I can't, somewhere near Karen.”	Mom		
Thinks Mom would be glad of help with the yard now.	David	Mom says she isn't ready for that	
Would want David to handle her bills if she couldn't.	Mom		Karen will ask an elder law attorney what that takes

What not to decide yet

The four things below don't need settling today. Some are Mom's to decide in her own time, and some belong with a professional who knows the rules where she lives. Leave them open and write down the questions.

- Where Mom will live.
- Who will have legal authority to act for her. That's a question for an elder law attorney.
- Anything about moving, gifting or retitling money or property, or about buying or cancelling insurance.
- Who is right.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the notes and send them to everyone, Mom included.
- Who will take each open question to your Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney, or a licensed financial or insurance professional.
- When you'll talk again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't resolve a disagreement, decide anything for Mom, or tell you what a professional will say. It gets what she wants onto one page, with the differences left on it. Rules vary by state, and nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has heard what Mom wants, and it's on one page with the open questions beside it. The planning interview takes it from there: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring, with your notes, to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The question about who Mom would want handling her money and her healthcare decisions follows one AARP suggests families ask. The other questions come from the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own outline for this step.

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
2. AARP, A Legal Checklist for Family Caregivers